brother Sugriva on charges of betrayal, driving him into hiding with his ally Hanuman. During this time, Ravana kidnapped Sita and flew her to Lanka. It was above Kishkindha that Sita dropped her jewels. They were found by Sugriva and recognized by Rama when he and Lakshmana came looking for her. The rest, as they say, is more mythology.

Local lore has cooked up an elaborate schema of Ramayana sites at Hampi: the pond by which Sita's jewels fell; the cave where Sugriva hid them; the cave where Rama and Lakshmana stayed; the rocky ledge from where Rama fired the arrow to murder Vali; Rama's giant footprint in stone; etc. Hanuman, the local hero, was a huge favourite with Vijayanagar's sculptors and appears often, usually with a raised hand and an overlarge tail. A shrine in Anegundi, atop Anjeyanadri Hill, claims to be his birthplace.

Wandering the ruins, I meet a local villager who tells me about the raja of Anegundi, a descendant of the kings of Vijayanagar, including Krishnadevaraya. This heir to the defunct throne has a city home in Hospet. The next morning, after many false starts, I find his home, a plain house on an arterial street. An attendant lets me in and soon a man in his early forties emerges and shakes my hand. His name is—no prizes for guessing—Krishna Devaraya, eighteen generations apart from his famous namesake. I ask if I could talk to him about his family history and perhaps write about it. He is gracious and polite, explains that he is about to head out to work and invites me to his ancestral home in Anegundi village the next day.